

Google Photos

This photo storage and sharing service shot to fame after Google revealed it to the world in 2015 and made it available for Android, iOS and the web. Photo storage services were aplenty but what set Google Photos apart was the inclusion of powerful image recognition features, search and quick loading times. This enabled Photos to take the market by storm. Currently Photos users upload upwards of 1.2 Billion pictures per day.

A bit of history

We should be grateful for the creation of Google+ because the best thing to come out of Google+ is Google Photos. Originally, Google Photos was launched as an embedded feature inside Google's now ailing social network, Google+. But Google later decided to breathe life into it by releasing Photos as a standalone service in 2015 while also sounding the death knell for their Picasa service eventually. In its early iterations, Photos was plagued with slow mobile uploads especially for people with a relatively large library of on-device pictures. However, this was remedied quickly with internal fixes. We even had a workaround where Google Photos desktop uploader could be used for larger uploads which still works like a charm. As online services go, Google Photos has had a good time in the sun by and large with hardly any controversies except one where the app auto generated an album with the name "Gorillas" for pictures of two African Americans. Google issued an apology in this regard and removed the tag "Gorilla" from the app.

What it does, what it doesn't?

As the name implies, the major USP of Photos is that it is one of the only services that offers free and unlimited storage of pictures and videos with up to 16 megapixels for photos and 1080p resolution for videos respectively. Couple that with Google's homegrown search and content recognition capabilities within Photos, and you get the ability to search for places, people, pets and things. Although Photos offers basic photo editing functionality, it shouldn't be mistaken for a full-fledged dedicated photo editing service. Photoshop, Lightroom and Snapseed are the ones that do the job better. But what Photos is great at is auto-generating albums, grouping pictures having similar content and most importantly searching for what you want to find from your collection while being dummy-proof. Here are a few of the features that make Google Photos a powerful service: